not by any hostility to democratic social revolution and economic reform." How to distinguish support for democratic social revolution from opposition to communism in the Cuban situation was not entirely clear.[12]

Kennedy continued to meet with his advisers in the course of February and March 1961, trying to figure out whether the invasion plan submitted by the CIA was indeed the best way to deal with the problem. The president was caught between a number of conflicting agendas. He was determined to stop the spread of communism to the Western Hemisphere, but he was also eager to present a new face to the "sister republics" in Latin America, staying away from the use of American military might. Also at stake were US-Soviet relations, which Kennedy wanted to improve. He was told that time was running out, that he had to act, and he probably felt that the only way to reconcile his conflicting agendas was to take clandestine action in Cuba.

At a meeting with his advisers on February 8, 1961, Kennedy suggested the infiltration of the task force in small groups, with their first big operation to be conducted from Cuban bases, not "as an invasion force sent by the Yankees." Neither the CIA nor the military liked that idea. On March 11, the CIA's Bissell presented a memorandum that effectively rejected Kennedy's idea of infiltration of small groups, arguing that without air support and tanks guerrilla groups had little chance of making it from the beaches to the mountains. Bissell recommended instead "landing in full force." Kennedy was not pleased. Once again, he sent the CIA back to the drawing board, asking for a plan that would make the US involvement "less obvious."[13]

Four days later, on March 15, Bissell proposed an alternative plan. He still insisted on air support but suggested that the planes to be used in the operation be camouflaged as Cuban rather than American. To make the claim work, an airstrip on Cuban territory would be needed to serve as the base of operations for alleged anti-Castro rebels in the Cuban Air Force. Thus, suggested Bissell, the invasion force would immediately have to take over an area with a landing strip. Besides, given that deployment would take place in an "endocuticular manner," the territory captured by the landing force would have to be suitable for prolonged defense. Bissell proposed the beaches of the Bahía de Cochinos (Bay of Pigs), which were